

YASBANT NEGI



THE CORRIDOR OF PEACE

Following terrorist attacks at several places of worship across the country, Sufi leaders come together to create a civic organisation to help the government and society fight terrorism

■ By Farzand Ahmed

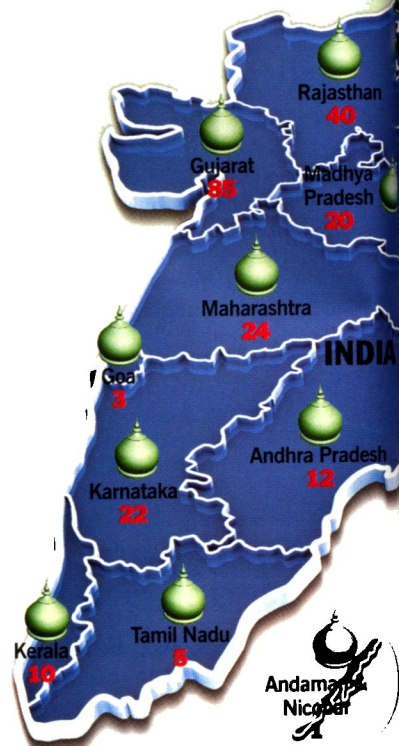
In December last year, All India Khwaja Gharib Nawaz Council, a Sufi organisation, led a peace march to Parliament, holding placards that read: "Islam says killing of one innocent is killing of humanity. Sufi Corridor can play an important role in establishing peace and unity." Despite the overly idealistic veneer, it marks an important milestone in the fight against Islamic terrorism. The Sufis in India are low profile but number close to 10 crore and their religious centres are spread across the country (see map). The movement to create a Sufi Corridor of peace is therefore a nationwide movement. Several Sufi scholars and saints belonging to various dargahs and khanqahs (Islamic seminaries) had gathered in Delhi recently to formally identify the corridor which stretches from Kashmir

to Kerala, Gujarat to West Bengal. The objective of the movement is to connect all Sufi centres with a view to uniting people against terrorism and try and prevent attacks at places sacred to both Hindus and Muslims. Sufism is based on the principle that "all people are the children of God on earth". Their philosophy has been to return hatred with love, violence with affection. So far it has largely been Sufi music which has found national resonance. Now, its religious leaders are hoping to do the same with their anti-terror campaign.

This is, in fact, the first-ever attempt to create a kind of civic organisation outside the boundaries of the political establishment to fight terrorism. The idea behind the initiative, according to internationally revered Sufi Syed Muhammad Jilani Ashraf Kichhau- chhvi, a direct descendent of Prophet Mohammad, who heads the Sufi

MYSTIC BELT

The Sufi Corridor will connect more than 400 prominent dargahs and khanqahs across the country



Foundation, Spiritual Foundation and Sufi University, and who was also part of the Delhi conference, is to connect all the famous dargahs and khanqahs, numbering close to 400, and reinforce the message of Sufism (Muslim mysticism) which, in strictly religious terms means cleansing of mind and heart to help acquire the knowledge of God, but in the current context is really to do with the brotherhood of man and coming together to fight terrorism.

Following the bomb explosions at the dargah of Khwaja Moinuddin Chishti at Ajmer Sharif on October 11, 2007, Maulana Jilani Ashraf, popularly known as Jilani Baba, made spiritual tours to different parts of the country to awaken and unite the Sufis. The Ajmer blast was preceded by the bomb blast at Mecca Masjid in Hyderabad on May 11, which killed 11 people. In fact, 10 days before the Delhi Sufi conference,